

Dissertation Proposal for PERIPHERAL PLAY PROSPECTS



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1 Topic of Investigation

(450/500 words)

Abstract

My topic of interest lies at the intersection of paratextual, corporeal, and sociocultural aspects of iconic game titles and their impact on the industry's history. Paratext consists of surrounding media not included in the game itself but strongly influencing how the experience is accessed, framed, and understood. Material comprises the physical means and contexts of play, in turn shaping the experience through sensory input, physical feedback, and presence. Society and culture permeate the above two aspects: while paratextuality is encoded in media and materiality is embedded in technology, the sociocultural layer is embodied by players themselves through their shared habits, beliefs, and informal systems. The co-operation of this trinity is flavoured by the aesthetics of the game playing experience in its entirety.

My project poses the following question:

In what ways can contemporary game design achieve holistic aesthetic experiences in the likeness of iconic, historically acclaimed game titles?

The research perspective is mostly aimed at context awareness and experiential revision, although, nostalgia remains a latent yet potent factor that bears investigation. Retrospective settings are being highlighted because most well-known titles from the past represent history as written by the victors.¹ With this in mind, I believe that game design can notably benefit from closely examining the external circumstances which frame any media product's release.

The theoretical research will examine existing frameworks established in game and media fields of study, intending to touch on fields and concepts such as experiential aesthetics, affect theory, procedural rhetoric, immersion, metagaming, preservation, and various design approaches. The practical review will survey an assortment of games whose play experience is notably characterised by contextual circumstances. This investigation is meant to derive patterns from exemplary case studies that can suggest ways of implanting the external layers of play experience into a new piece of playable media. With historical awareness providing the background, some of the findings will be incorporated into designing a digital artifact complementing the written one, accompanied by fictional context in the shape of lore and paraphernalia.

Comprehensive analysis of multiple real world scenarios is to be followed by a selection of applicable² approaches, which in turn will inform the directions taken throughout the design and development process. Concurrently, any relevant observations should be recorded with the intent to feed back into the writing and, eventually, provide a strong basis for reflection. Exercising theory in practice is expected to direct the unfolding of the game's design. The goal that I aspire to achieve with this project is tracing a model of media creation that is elevated by its surrounding context, and also aligns with key values established in my personal game design philosophy (GD5609, 2025), then put the resulting framework into future practice.

¹Or, in a few amusingly infamous cases, the kitschy underdogs and dark horses that are often both cautionary tales and subjects of cult following. Evidently, if one struggles to attain immortality via glory, becoming an anecdote remains a viable alternative.

²A word which here means (Snicket, 1999) "feasible".

KEYWORDS:
aesthetics,
authenticity,
experience,
immersion,
materiality,
metagaming,
nostalgia,
paraphernalia,
paratext,
preservation,
retrospective,
transmedia

2 Survey of Sources

(960/1500 words)

Why is the research being undertaken? because vibes!

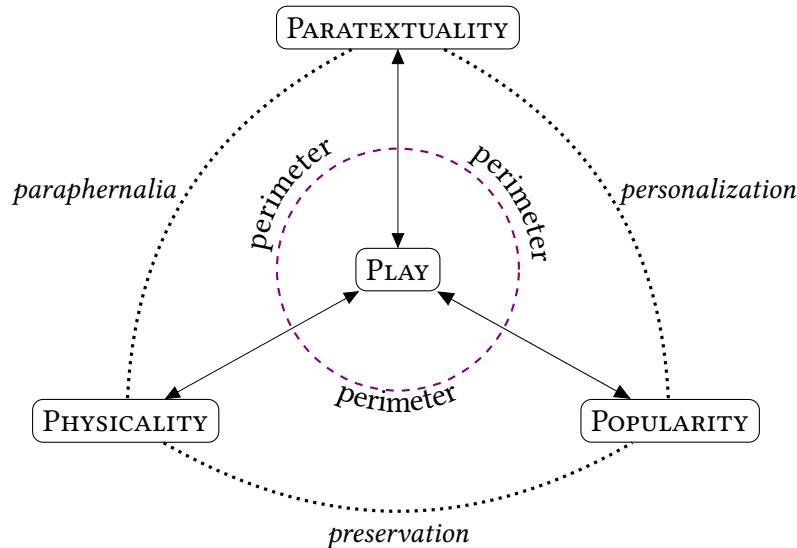


Figure 1: Peripheral aspects of play outside the magic circle's perimeter

2.1 Literature Review

Paratextuality, a.k.a. Supporting Context

The initial concept by Gérard Genette (1997) has been considerably expanded to better fit the field of game studies (Consalvo, 2007), and as a result has been entangled with adjacent terms from the original scholar's typology.³ However, both approaches can be integrated into my own, owing to the generous overlap between the three types of external context.

When strictly categorising cases, Genette's definition regards "Elements that form a figurative threshold of a text and ground it in a socio-historical context. [...] must be created by the text's producers or their associates". These can be promotional materials, introductory sequences, menus, credits, making-ofs, contextual information about authors.

Meanwhile, Consalvo's interpretation covers "Any element that forms a figurative threshold of a text and grounds it in a socio-historical context. [...] no limitations on authorship or cultural status.", akin to *cultural epiphenomena*. This allows the inclusion of more elements like "criticism and journalism, user discussions, fan fiction and fan art, streaming, trans-media storytelling" (Švelch, 2020).

On these grounds, Genette's delineation is the more clear and straightforward directive for labelling purposes, while Consalvo's expansion on it draws a connection to cultural assimilation. Additionally, both have ties to materiality in their manifestation.

Physicality, a.k.a. Material Elements

³The five aspects of *transtextuality* are *inter-*, *meta-*, *hyper-*, *archi-*, and *para-*texts.

The most tangible of the three aspects, this refers to all the material conditions in which the game is played. Exclusively, this covers authentic hardware and peripherals, physical data storage, haptic features, and environmental settings. In addition, paratextual supplements in physical format, e.g., paper, fall under the same category to form paraphernalia.

Popularity, a.k.a. Cultural Impact

Culture and society permeate the first two aspects via informal systems of shared habits, beliefs and conventions. The formation of social rituals by the demographic over time leads to emergent paratext, stemming from reception and circulation, and physical aspects are embodied in player presence and direct interaction with the hardware.

2.2 Precedent Review

Upon stepping out of secondary academic sources, a plethora of real world situations present themselves as use case candidates. Each listed item listed regards contemporaneous circumstances like demographic situations, business models of companies, and the technologies (both physical and software products) available, all of which steered the creative and commercial development of game titles.

While it is not imperative to audit them all individually, I would like to present here the aspects of paratextual, material, and cultural enrichments that were pivotal to their elevation.

Pong

This entry also encompasses early arcade video games and first generation home consoles line-up, with Pong (Alcorn, 1972) as the paragon title. Their appeal lies beyond squares bouncing off rectangles, and is rooted in the outset of screen interactivity.

PARATEXTUALITY

It predates standard paratextual materials, but it could be said that the debut of load-bearing elements, like cabinet art, operator manuals, and arcade configurations, elegantly set a precedent.

PHYSICALITY

Physical context in the original arcade cabinets was already embodied in the requirement to be present, but the tactile precision of rotary analogue dials allowed the players to feel rooted into a simulation of a real-life table tennis match.

POPULARITY

It allowed for the onset of spectatorship. The customers of Andy Capp's Tavern had no way of knowing that this novelty would eventually be canonised as the catalyst of early video game industry. They simply watched others compete while waiting for their own turn. Before its historical recognition, Pong simply offered a tangible shared experience, in the right place, at the right time.

Textual Tradition

Type-in Software

PARATEXTUALITY

The code page is an actual part of the game, that the player inputs as the first act of participation.

PHYSICALITY

Typing games into existence, bridging analogue and digital; machine -> paper -> machine; One typo could break everything - it was a fragile and tactile, but owned. Player involvement in creating or modifying the game, physical-digital bridge.

POPULARITY

learning some coding by necessity, Users often learned about BASIC or machine code doing this.; Engagement & DIY Culture - Encourages direct involvement in creating or modifying the game.

Infocom

Distributed *feelies* for text adventures like *Zork I* (1980) and *Suspended: A Cryogenic Nightmare* (1983)

PARATEXTUALITY AND PHYSICALITY

In this case, the two are tightly intertwined by design. The materials were gameplay elements integrated *outside* the digital scope of the games feturing them.

POPULARITY

The various goodies showed alternative ways of engagement as one of the early examples of trans-media storytelling.

Inscription

MUDs and early MMOs (Trubshaw & Bartle, 1978)

PARATEXTUALITY

extra content
Text-based, often running on university servers or via dial-up.

PHYSICALITY

physical stuff
The gameplay revolved around shared narrative construction, community building, and player-driven worlds. Early MMOs like Ultima Online and EverQuest expanded this to graphical, persistent worlds with social rituals, economies, and emergent storytelling. The sense of presence emerged through text or simple graphics combined with imagination. Demands of tech and scheduling affected play rhythms.

POPULARITY

social rituals
Immersion in world and identity building in persistent online spaces Social virtual worlds and emergent identity creation and online community dynamics. Social Spaces as Core Feature Players were often co-creators, shaping lore, communities, and even rules. Community dynamics formed the metagame with the rise of player politics, guilds, and conventions. Nostalgia & Cultural Memory - Early MUDs are often remembered fondly as social spaces beside games.

Transmedia Storytelling

Swordquest Atari's Swordquest contest extended gameplay beyond screens to the real world by mixing physical and digital elements:

1. Earthworld (1982) introduced the series' puzzle-driven model, integrating comics, game mechanics, and a real-world treasure hunt for a solid gold talisman; launched with a DC Comic tie-in and puzzle contest

2. Fireworld (1983a) leaned further into cryptic puzzle design and real-world participation. Its solution required synthesizing symbolic logic from in-game events and comic references; continued the trans-media puzzle format with a new comic and prize quest
3. Waterworld (1983b) was the (unintentionally) final released in limited numbers, making it a rare case of high-concept interactive media collapsing due to external economic factors (the 1983 crash) - a cautionary historical moment; prize was still awarded though

PARATEXTUALITY

PHYSICALITY

POPULARITY

extra content

physical stuff

social rituals

AR Games Sicart, 2016

ARGs like Frog Fractions 2 or Pokémon GO - real-world participation, secrecy, and communal knowledge.

Curated Retro Compilations

Digital Eclipse

Their efforts in authentic and curatorial preservation are evident in “Atari 50: The Anniversary Celebration”, “Teenage Mutant Ninja Turtles: The Cowabunga Collection”, and even more so in their *Gold Series* of interactive documentaries, starting with “The Making of Karateka” and including “Llamasoft: The Jeff Minter Story” and “Tetris Forever”.

PARATEXTUALITY AND PHYSICALITY

POPULARITY

Interactive timeline museums where physical paratext is digitised; Archival materials (concept art, pitch documents, developer commentary) as interactive content.

Metagame - play the in-the-moment cultural context.

Sega Genesis Classics (Sega, 2018)

Compare approach with DE: education vs. nostalgia

PARATEXTUALITY

PHYSICALITY

POPULARITY

Aesthetic vs. archival: It simulates the feel, not the making-of. No material outside the bedroom

Replicate childhood gaming by framing ROMs within a stylised memory space.; Nostalgia Theatre: A 1990s bedroom with a CRT TV, a shelf of cartridges, and other dressing like posters, lava lamps, beanbags

Theatricality vs. Fidelity: It romanticises the idea of an era

Foundational NES Titles

Dragon Quest I (Chunsoft, Yuji Horii, 1986)

Early JRPG with lots of wandering, grinding, and guesswork. QoL changes in remasters remove friction. Friedrich Kittler emphasizes how media technology determines UX - NES constraints + JRPG design = a new literacy. Questions: What is left of a game's intended experience once its context is stripped away? Can design elements once seen as "limitations" be re-evaluated as experiential depth? How did early JRPGs rely on extra-diegetic tools (manuals, maps, player-created notes)?

PARATEXTUALITY

Original JP release had a detailed manual with monster illustrations, hints, lore, and walkthroughs; later titles also saw promotional manga and other media support.

PHYSICALITY

lengthy play sessions, manual-driven mechanics; manual notation of maps, quests, and clues. box art, manual, and cartridge were the game as much as the 8-bit world onscreen. Commitment shaped by hardware constraints, difficulty, as well as a contrived saving system in the JP version.

POPULARITY

Cultural Moment In Japan, it was released into an infant console gaming culture. The response helped shape how audiences engaged with fantasy and how RPGs developed worldwide.

Legend of Zelda (Nintendo EAD, Shigeru Miyamoto, 1986)

PARATEXTUALITY

Manuals, guides, Nintendo Power

PHYSICALITY

Manuals, guides, Nintendo Power, mapping

POPULARITY

external collaboration, knowledge sharing as a social currency?

Tunic

Startropics (Nintendo Integrated Research & Development, 1990)

PARATEXTUALITY

Serves as a mechanic; like Infocom's feelies, it's between fundamental and supplemental

PHYSICALITY

External Narrative Elements requiring real-world interaction to progress; A letter packed with the game needed to be dipped in water to reveal a secret code (747).

POPULARITY

Consequences of removing/simulating physical components in digital releases; Nintendo hotline trends;

Mario Paint (Nintendo R&D1, 1992)

PARATEXTUALITY

extra content

PHYSICALITY

The SNES mouse peripheral introduced a creative method of interaction. POPULARITY

social rituals

Legacy in Ring Fit Adventure and Nintendo Labo

Dragon's Lair (Advanced Microcomputer Systems, 1983)

Immersive Presentation: A case of experiential obsolescence and preservation challenges.

PARATEXTUALITY

Context-Dependent Play

PHYSICALITY

The fragility of experience tied to hardware & setting

POPULARITY

The quality of the gameplay experience is entirely dependant on the setting in which it is attempted (that is to say it is relatively obsolete now, though significantly influential for its time)

Mention VR titles like Half-Life: Alyx.

Doom (id Software, 1993)

Technical breakthrough and modding culture shaping player agency and community. Relevance: A milestone in tech-driven immersion, multiplayer, and player-created content. Unique Focus: Emphasizes shareware distribution, modding culture, and emergent multiplayer experiences. Distinguishes itself by: Showcasing technology's role in shaping community and cultural phenomena. 1. Technical Breakthrough & Experiential Leap Doom was revolutionary for bringing fast-paced, immersive 3D-like gameplay to home computers. It ran on widely available hardware, but pushed boundaries - allowing players to feel like they were "inside" a game world for the first time. The networked multiplayer aspect introduced new social dynamics (death-matches, co-op). The experience was the rush of playing something new, fluid, intense. 2. Distribution & Modding Culture Doom popularized shareware distribution. This facilitated the early modding scene, where players created and shared WADs. Game's "life" was extended beyond the original release. Its materiality is an ecosystem of player-generated content, forums, and zines. How Doom Fits Your Themes Physicality of Play Hardware choices and physical setup influenced play intensity and social gatherings (LAN parties). Meta Gaming Doom's modding community exemplifies metagaming as an extension of play and cultural relevance. Questions How did Doom's novel tech and shareware model redefine the player's relationship with games and communities? In what ways did physical hardware and social context enhance or limit the "original" Doom experience? How does the modding culture around Doom reflect early forms of metagaming and participatory culture?

PARATEXTUALITY

extra content

PHYSICALITY

physical stuff

POPULARITY

social rituals

Celebrations of Circumstances

Feature Phone Mobile Games (J2ME/BREE era) Boom in Japan

Ubiquitous handheld play integrated into daily life rhythms; mobile gaming scene before smartphones Gaming on-the-go, often during commutes or small pockets of free time. Temporal, spatial, and ergonomic constraints. 1. Environment Driven Design - tailored to short bursts, played standing up in trains or waiting at stations. Navigation designed for T9 input, small screens, and no touch; clarity and feedback prioritised over sound 2. Networked Paratext Many of these were subscription-based, offered via carrier portals (like i-mode by NTT Docomo). Games were part of an ecosystem of ringtones, wallpapers, manga, and communication tools. Part of a wider lifestyle aesthetic. 3. Transience and Cultural Memory These games often weren't preserved, and emulating them is notoriously difficult. Yet they were formative for a whole generation - influencing everything from gacha mechanics to asynchronous multiplayer. They became folk games of a sort: shared, modified, talked about more than archived. Theory Metagaming The ecosystem (portal + phone + community) is the game. McLuhan - The medium is the message The form factor (commuter phone) shaped behaviors and design logic. Miyazaki's Ludic Nostalgia (????) Does this era reflect a Japanese-specific yearning for transient, everyday magic - gaming anonymously amid others? Question: Can games built for transient or ephemeral contexts still produce deep emotional resonance?

PARATEXTUALITY

extra content

PHYSICALITY

physical stuff

POPULARITY

social rituals

Dragon Quest i-mode remakes - stripped-down, episodic versions designed for 10-minute sessions. RPGs like Elminage or Wizardry Gaiden . Konami's i-appli ports of classic games, reinterpreted for d-pad and one-handed controls.

Cosy COVID Nintendo EPD, 2020

Comfort games as safe spaces during historical moment of crisis; slow, reflective, and socially connective play; Environment and UI (simple tools, gentle music, slow pace) tuned to match a collective emotional state

PARATEXTUALITY

Paratextual ecosystem (memes, tutorials, fan guides, in-game design templates)

PHYSICALITY

physical stuff

POPULARITY

Launched days after global lockdowns began Filled the social void through visiting friends' islands Gained traction as a shared, ritualised, soothing routine People made birthday parties, weddings, protests, in-game markets, art installations and fashion shows emergent social value and community-building. Physical/social context (quarantine, anxiety, disconnection) giving meaning

Other titles with shared elements flourishing in the same era: Stardew Valley, Spiritfarer, Among Us, Cozy Grove, Unpacking. They often feature physical-world metaphors (gardening, home decorating, friendship building); Low-stress, high-emotion mechanics; Emphasis on customisation, routine, and community

Include UFO50, Tunic, Outer Wilds, Hypnospace Outlaw

Peripherals: Light Gun, Labo, Ring Fit for embodied play

3 Methodology

(34/200 words)

Justify and explain:
how the methods support the research and inform practice
why they are the best option
what approach you will take,
what will you focus on (art, mechanics, tech and interface implementation, etc.),
and how this all connects to the question.
How will the game incorporate the methods?.

In order to tackle the research question, the following methods are under consideration:

Textual, ludic and comparative analyses and syntheses

Will be used for scholarly research, deconstructing key game precedents, and formulating the main thesis.

Theoretical framework conceptualisation and application

Triple P

Research through design (RtD)

What does it mean?

source

Media archaeology and (maybe) reception studies

hardware, display fidelity, manual paraphernalia

Autoethnography

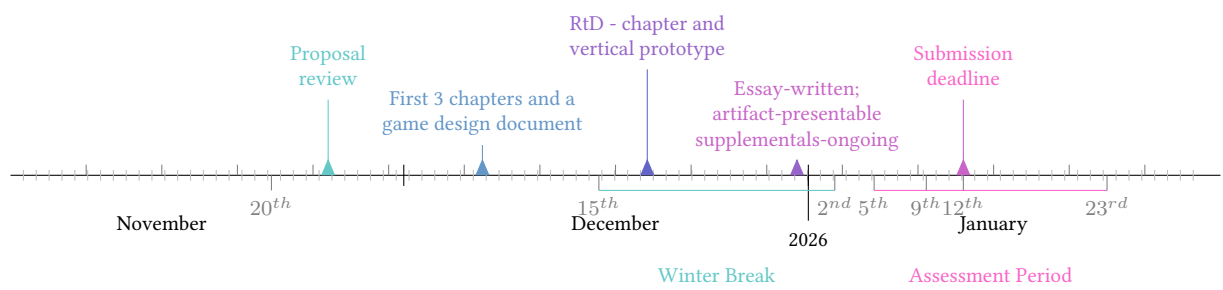
to test claims

4 Production Plan

(218/100 words)

Essay Writing	Game Prototype
<i>Proposal</i> document and review	Initial concept ideation in a paragraph
<i>Introduction, Literature Review, and Case Studies</i> chapters	Design document outlining concept and specs to be used as the first piece of supplemental material
<i>Research through Design</i> chapter	Vertical/Proof-of-Concept build; manual booklet draft
<i>Synthesis and Conclusion</i> chapters	Playable game, guide and/or magazine page drafts
Editing and finalising writing	Late stage game development; finalising paraphernalia

Figure 2: Above: Progress stages to complete in parallel:
Below:Project pipeline with progress milestones, dates are subject to change



Approach As long as its laden with enough peripheral context, the practical component can be of any genre to begin with. In essence, it must be a meta-game, which poses as either a modern piece with retro sensibilities, or a remaster of an ersatz effigy from an alternative, but not too unlike our own, reality. Since the eventual aim of this research project is to understand how to achieve the former, perhaps the latter would be a better subject for experimentation.

Hides crucial lore in the periphery, without which it cannot be completed

Elements and Features

Manual (instructional play), guides, prompts in varied formats (e.g., real-world clues), magazine pages, reviews, developer commentary, margin notes and illustrations, ads and headlines (for flavour). Reinforcement of manual discovery, note-taking and blind exploration

Control peripherals, printables (above)

World-building with historical Events (or contests), Word-of-mouth rumour simulation

Scope

Differentiate between real and replicated constraints (time, skill, vs. media, software/hardware)

Speculate on scale vs. feasibility and layer implementation plans vertically

Technology Toolset:

ΛT_EX is my preferred typesetting system, which I will extensively use to produce documents for both the written component and any potential paraphernalia, such as maps, guides, or manuals.

Unity is the 3D game engine I am most familiar with, offering lots of versatility and good supporting documentation and teaching materials. HOWEVER

Godot is a lightweight and versatile open-source 2D and 3D game engine that I have been meaning to explore as an alternative.

Git is the version control standard, so **GitHub** will archive all documentation and source code.

Assets will be sourced mostly from open content websites.

- Q itch.io(2013) - the topmost provider and a favoured digital distribution platform for indie developers
- Q kenney.nl(2010) - offers various 2D and 3D asset packs that congruously fit together
- Q quaternius.com(2018) - similarly to Kenney's, this online collection operates under a *CC0 (Creative Commons Zero) open source license*, and features a sizeable line-up of 3D assets
- Q opengameart.org(2009) - mildly chaotic in comparison to the options listed above, but a large and long lived library for libre content

5 Chapter Breakdown

(350/200 words)

Introduction

~400 words / 5%

Declaration of the research topic and question, their field, and relevance to game studies;
Clarification of vocabulary such as ‘holistic’ and ‘authenticity’, as well as ‘experiential aesthetics’;
Pitch of the practical part and its connection to the writing.

⚙️ METHODS: Contextual framing and problem definition

💡 SOURCES: Overview of primary and secondary titles



Literature Review

~2400 words / 30%

Definition of key terminology; contextualising the P-trinity through the secondary sources.

⚙️ METHODS: Thematic synthesis, conceptual frameworking

💡 SOURCES:

- Friedrich Adolf Kittler versus Marshall McLuhan (McLuhan, 1964) on media theory
- “Paratextuality in Game Studies: A Theoretical Review and Citation Analysis”, an article by Jan Švelch (2020)
- *Mechanisms: New Media and the Forensic Imagination*, a book by M.G. Kirschenbaum (2012)
- “Platform Studies: Frequently Questioned Answers”, a conference paper by Ian Bogost and Nick Montfort (2009)
- “Social Realism in Gaming”, an article by Alexander Galloway (2004)
- *Metagaming: Playing, Competing, Spectating, Cheating, Trading, Making, and Breaking Videogames*, a book by Stephanie Boluk and Patrick Lemieux (2017)
- *Cheating: Gaining Advantage in Videogames*, a book by Mia Consalvo (2007)
- *Digital Playgrounds: The Hidden Politics of Children’s Online Play Spaces, Virtual Worlds, and Connected Games*, a book by Sara Margaret Grimes (2021)
- “The Cultural Field of Video Game Production in Australia”, an article by Brendan Keogh (2019)
- *Always Already New: Media, History, and the Data of Culture*, a book by L. Gitelman (2008)
- *Confronting the Challenges of Participatory Culture: Media Education for the 21st Century*, a book by Henry Jenkins (2009)
- *Play Between Worlds: Exploring Online Game Culture*, a book by T.L. Taylor (2009)

possibly optional



Case Studies

~1800 words / 22.5%

Framing real-life settings in the context of paratextuality, physicality, and popularity;
Further analysis to extract practical inferences.

⚙️ METHODS: Media archaeology, theoretical framework application, ludic and paratextual analysis, comparative synthesis

💡 SOURCES: A curated subset of primary sources listed in Section 2.2, along with:

- “Reality has Always Been Augmented: Play and the Promises of Pokémon GO”, a book by Miguel Angel Sicart (2016)
- Fan-based zines and archives, e.g., Your Sinclair, Commodore User, Compute!, Antic, etc.
- The Internet Archive / The Wayback Machine (1996)



Development

~1400 words / 17.5%

Chronicle of the RtD process and explanation how,
in designing a prototype to interrogate a question, theory informed practice and vice versa;
Recognition/acknowledgement of any setbacks or limitations.

- ⚙️ METHODS: Research through Design, Ludic/comparative analysis
- 💡 SOURCES: Primary sources with strong parallels to my direction; plus guidance from reading:
 - *Making deep games: Designing games with meaning and purpose*, a book by Doris C. Rusch (2017)



Synthesis

~1600 words / 20%

Revision of the artifact; Discussion on theory in practice:
how the two informed, or clashed with, each other;
Correlation with primary sources;
Provisional answer to the research question.

- ⚙️ METHODS: Comparative ludic analysis, auto-ethnographic reflection
- 💡 SOURCES: Secondary sources that share concerns with the artifact



Conclusion

~400 words / 5%

Reflection of what has been achieved;
Outline of implications and further open-ended research directions to build upon.

- ⚙️ METHODS: Critical reflection and projection
- 💡 SOURCES: Recommendations for reading/playing not mentioned in earlier chapters



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'Is it mandatory to add **date played**? I don't see much value in that information: some I have played ages ago while some I have not at all but am sufficiently informed about.'

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